Jain Samaj, Gandhi Bhawan, Ramakrishna Mission and Chinmaya Mission visited Tihar. Apart from the aforementioned luminaries, a vast spectrum of visitors also came to help Tihar actually move towards becoming an ashram. For instance: counsellors, linguists and storytellers, writers, doctors (both generalists and specialists), practising allopathy, homoeopathy, Ayurveda, naturopathy and others, psychiatrists, Gandhians, theologians, evangelists, social workers, members from the prison fellowships, computer experts, social science researchers, teachers (educational, moral and spiritual), priests, artistes (from the theatre and also musicians), sportspersons, crèche workers, legal aid advocates, librarians, bankers, vocational training specialists, horticulturists and donors.

His Holiness the Dalai Lama expressed his desire to visit Tihar and bless the prisoners personally.

Since the visits of the aforementioned luminaries and other categories had great information value for the people outside, even when the media was not directly present in the prison, they got due coverage. However, a few of them had brought along their own media entourage as well. The fact of the matter was that the media was no longer buying news but seeing and reporting directly. This strengthened the information base for the prison and brought in more and more community support for the reforms taking place. There has not been a single instance of sensational news that had a destructive effect on reforms in Tihar. In fact, what people got through the news was 'Tihar as it is'.

Such news obviously would transcend the boundaries of the country. Foreign media naturally would also have an interest not only because many foreign nationals were housed in Tihar but also because of the human interest angle. After all, prisons exist all over the world and some problems are similar. They started to show keenness in special culture-based reform programmes that were unique to Tihar and the Indian ethos, such as *Vipassana* meditation, spiritual discourses, yoga, community support to total literacy, the petition box system, drug abuse treatment, keeping of small children with their mothers and how the prison could accept being a nosmoking zone.

Kiran saw no reason for depriving the media persons of letting them know and see Tihar as it was. While this did prove a big boon for Indian human rights handling, it also got her invitations from abroad to enable interaction amongst prison systems facing the kind of challenges that Tihar did.

But this was not how her seniors thought! Permitting any media into Tihar Jail began to be construed as a compromise on security. Her acceptance of invitations abroad began to be construed as manipulation of foreign trips. Denial of banned items to politically favoured prisoners was construed as a deliberate bias towards the Delhi State Government. Also, her inability, because of circumstances beyond her control, to keep an appointment sought by herself with the chief minister was construed as her not wanting to work for the Delhi State Government. This was, indeed, a volte face of the extreme kind. What could have triggered off this snowball effect? In this context, several factors stand out for detailed consideration.

As stated earlier, Kiran had received a personal invitation from the Congressional Committee of the Senate of the United States of America to be their guest at a National Prayer Breakfast in the first week of January 1994. She requested clearance from the Home Ministry and, meanwhile, made her bookings. A day *after* her intended date of departure, she received a denial of permission from the ministry. The invitation, however, was repeated for the year 1995 and the media was quick to ask her whether she thought she would again be denied permission. Her candid reply was that that probably was what would happen. However, she got an okay the second time and was able to attend the breakfast meet.

This invitation was soon followed by another from the United Nations to attend a World Summit for Social Development in Copenhagen, Denmark, in March 1995. She was requested to exchange views with other participants there on the situation of prisoners as she saw it. Now this was very much a